of orange juice. It looked a little oily but I just said, "More orange juice! Good!" and took a swig.

Now, there are some tastes you never forget. What there was in that orange juice I had taken only once before, when I was a boy of no more than eight—but I remembered it at once.

"Castor oil!" I said, aghast.

"Finish it," said the nurse, austerely.

I finished it. That night, I did not sleep.

I have never had any need for laxatives. I am always perfectly regular. Therefore, to dope me with a good, strong one created havoc. I was up all night emptying. I think my alimentary canal must have sent out for extras.

The next day they injected into one of my veins an iodine-containing compound that was opaque to X rays, waited till it was being

eliminated through the urinary tract, took the necessary X rays, and located the kidney stone. It was partway down the left ureter.

They told me that I might pass it if I drank a lot of water constantly and never let myself get dehydrated. Not only would that help pass the stone but also it would keep me from forming others.

(When I was told all this, I suddenly remembered that once my father had told me that a doctor had said he had "sand in the urine." These were probably crystals, tiny stones. The tendency to stone formation was undoubtedly inherited.)

They sent me home and told me that if I didn't pass the stone in two weeks to come back and they would probe for it.

Weill I didn't intend to do that unless forced into it, so I spent the next few weeks drinking water. As I said bitterly on numerous occasions afterward: Other people drink when they're thirsty; I drink when I pass the sink.

It meant frequent visits to the bathroom, all the more so since the urinary tract was irritated, especially when the stone worked itself lower and began to push the button that signaled "You've got to go." (It also meant that, to this day, if I ever sleep through the night without having to get up at least once to visit the